# STAYMAN CONVENTION

## ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

## STAYMAN CONVENTION SUMMARY

When one partner opens 1NT it is difficult to uncover a 4-4 Major fit using only natural bidding. The Stayman Convention solves the problem and improves bidding accuracy as well. As an additional benefit, when you use Stayman the 1NT Opener usually becomes the Declarer on the hand, thereby keeping the stronger hand concealed.

The Stayman Convention is worthwhile even if it is the only convention you use. However, there are added benefits to using Stayman in conjunction with Jacoby Transfers. The two work smoothly together with Stayman taking care of those hands where Responder has a 4-card Major(s) and Jacoby Transfers taking care of those hands where Responder has a 5- or 6-card Major.

The actual working of Stayman is simple:
Following a 1NT opening, Responder will only use Stayman when he holds at least one 4-card Major suit.
He does so by bidding 2♣ which requires Opener to reply as follows:

- With no 4-card Major suit he bids 2♦.
- With a 4-card ♥ suit, (and possibly 4 ♠s as well), he bids 2♥.
- With a 4-card ♠ suit, (but not 4 ♥s), he bids 2♠.

It really is as simple as that. Well, almost.

Stayman takes much of the guesswork (sometimes called judgement) out of the bidding and steers you directly to these two goals:

1. With a partnership 26 points you will reach game, with 33 you will reach slam.
2. With a partnership 8+ cards in a Major suit you will play in that suit, otherwise you will play notrump.

For the first point consider this table which is based on the 1NT opener holding 15-17 points.

| Resp Points | Opener Points | | | Bidding Target |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 15 | 16 | 17 | |
| 8 | 23 | 24 | 25 | Partscore |
| 9 | 24 | 25 | 26 | |
| 10 | 25 | 26 | 27 | |
| 11 | 26 | 27 | 28 | |
| 12 | 27 | 28 | 29 | Game |
| 13 | 28 | 29 | 30 | |
| 14 | 29 | 30 | 31 | |
| 15 | 30 | 31 | 32 | |
| 16 | 31 | 32 | 33 | |
| 17 | 32 | 33 | 34 | Slam |
| 18 | 33 | 34 | 35 | |

Responder's actions are as follows:

- 8 points or fewer - usually pass, but may use Stayman and then pass
- 9 points - invite partner to game
- 10 points - either invite or force to game, using your judgement
- 11-15 points - force to game
- 16 points - invite to slam
- 17 points - either invite or force to slam, using your judgement
- 18 points or more - force to slam

Opener's actions are as follows:

- 15 points - decline invitations
- 16 points - either decline or accept, using your judgement
- 17 points - accept invitations

As to the second point above (the 8-card trump fit) Responder is usually in charge.

- If Opener shows a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks that suit.
- If Opener does not show a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks notrump.

Opener usually has no say in the suit selection, with this important exception:
If Opener holds 4 cards in **EACH** Major suit he responds 2♥.
Should Responder then bid notrump, indicating a dislike for ♥s, Opener should bid ♠s because she knows there is a 4-4 ♠ fit,

Some comments are in order about the point count methods used on these pages.
Initial point count for both hands is based on 4-3-2-1 plus one point for a fifth card in a suit.
Revalued points (only after a trump fit is discovered) are +1 for a doubleton, +2 for a singleton and +3 for a void. Both hands should count these revalued short-suit points; Opener of course would not have a singleton or void.

One more point. Stayman should definitely be used after 2NT openings as well.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥7

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥7

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠3

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦K

***Board 1***
North Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A J 8 5<br>♥ K J<br>♦ A K 8<br>♣ K J 9 6 | |
| ♠ 7 3<br>♥ 8 6 5<br>♦ Q J 10 9 7<br>♣ A Q 3 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 10 9 6<br>♥ 7 2<br>♦ 6 5 4 3 2<br>♣ 10 5 2 |
| | ♠ K Q 4 2<br>♥ A Q 10 9 4 3<br>♦ —<br>♣ 8 7 4 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 2NT | Pass | 3♣ |
| Pass | 3♠ | Pass | 6♠ |
| All Pass | | | |

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥7

North opens 2NT.

Wow! Start thinking slam, but first things first. Find the suit by starting with Stayman. You bid 3♣ and partner replies 3♠. What do you say next?

Your hand revalues to 16 points now that you know there's a ♠ fit. So certainly you want to be in slam as long as there are not two quick ♣ losers. At this point you might try something like a 4♦ cue bid, hoping partner will read that as a slam try in ♠s, but denying the ♣ control. But that seems awfully easy to be misunderstood. We suggest an immediate 6♠.

Good thing it's being played by North, right?

***Board 2***
East Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ J 10 5<br>♥ Q J<br>♦ A K 9<br>♣ J 9 6 4 2 | |
| ♠ Q 7 4 2<br>♥ 10 9 8 3<br>♦ J 8 7 6 3<br>♣ — |  | ♠ A 8 3<br>♥ A K 6 4<br>♦ Q 5 2<br>♣ Q 8 7 |
| | ♠ K 9 6<br>♥ 7 5 2<br>♦ 10 4<br>♣ A K 10 5 3 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1NT | Pass |
| 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ | |
| All Pass | | | |

2♥ by East
Lead: ♣K

East opens 1NT.

Your first thought should be that with only 4 points you will pass. But on second thought, what would partner respond if you bid a Stayman 2♣? So you give it a shot and partner says 2♥. What next?

What's next is your PASS. And if he had bid 2♠ you also would have passed. And if he had bid 2♦ you also would have passed. You figured that with this hand any response partner could make would be a better place than 1NT.

***Board 3***
South Deals
E-W Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q J 8 5<br>♥ K 6 4<br>♦ Q J 7<br>♣ K 10 8 | |
| ♠ 4 2<br>♥ Q 10 8 7 3<br>♦ A 10 6 3<br>♣ 6 3 |  | ♠ 10 9 6<br>♥ J 2<br>♦ K 5 4<br>♣ J 9 7 5 4 |
| | ♠ A K 7 3<br>♥ A 9 5<br>♦ 9 8 2<br>♣ A Q 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1NT |
| Pass | 3NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by South
Lead: ♥7

South opens 1NT.

With 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit this fits the model for Stayman.

But thinking a little further, with this 4-3-3-3 distribution you have no ruffing values whatsoever. So even if partner also has 4 ♠s there might not be an advantage in playing the suit contract. So for this specific distribution you ignore your 4-card Major and just bid 3NT.

***Board 4***
South Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 3<br>♥ 9 8 6 5 3<br>♦ K 8 6 2<br>♣ 6 3 2 | |
| ♠ 9 8<br>♥ K J 4<br>♦ A Q J 7<br>♣ A 10 8 5 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ A Q 10 6<br>♥ Q 7<br>♦ 10 9 5<br>♣ K 9 7 4 |
| | ♠ K J 7 5 4 2<br>♥ A 10 2<br>♦ 4 3<br>♣ Q J | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Pass |
| 1NT | Pass | 2♣ | 2♠ |
| Pass | Pass | 3NT | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by West
Lead: ♠3

After you open 1NT partner bids 2♣, then South says 2♠. What do you say next?

Basically you said your say when you opened 1NT. You don't have a 4-card Major and you have a minimum hand. The best way to convey this information to partner is to pass. At which point partner jumps to 3NT.

Pass, then "Thank you partner" when dummy comes down. The thing to remember is that partner is in charge. You describe your hand as well as you can and then sit back and let him make the decisions. Perhaps you would have doubled if you held his hand but he didn't.

***Board 5***
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 6 3
♥ 9 8 5 2
♦ 9 5
♣ J 10 9 6

♠ A 8
♥ K J 7 4
♦ A 7 2
♣ K Q 5 3




♠ J 7 5 4
♥ 6
♦ K Q J 10 8 4
♣ A 2

♠ K Q 10 2
♥ A Q 10 3
♦ 6 3
♣ 8 7 4

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1NT | 2♦ | 3♦ |
| Pass | 3♥ | Pass | 4♥ |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by North
Lead: ♦K

North opens 1NT and East overcalls 2♦.

Dad-burned interfering opponents. You were going to bid a Stayman 2♣ and now you can't. You also don't want to bid either Major with only 4 of them. And you certainly can't bid notrump with no ♦ stopper. Fortunately the overcall has opened a window of opportunity for you. So you cue-bid 3♦. Even if you and partner haven't discussed this it is pretty obvious that you don't really want to play in ♦s, so the most likely action for him is to bid a suit, and a Major suit would have priority. So really, the cue-bid achieves the same purpose as Stayman would have.

Partner now bids 3♥.

Partner showed a 4-card ♥ suit. With your 4 that makes a fit. You have 12 revalued points so you bid 4♥.